VOC was in the thick of all this drama. Finally, when the Extremist delegates met separately, VOC was elected the secretary of the Madras wing of the new Nationalist Party. He thus became *the* acknowledged leader of the Swadeshi movement in Madras Presidency. On their return, the Chennai Jana Sangam—an organization for 'the furtherance of "Nationalism" … by delivering lectures on Swadeshism and boycott, by founding a school for physical culture, a reading room and library, and lastly, by training young men to preach on Swadeshism and boycott'—was founded with VOC heading the list of office bearers.[8]

Neelakanta Brahmachari, the first accused in the Ashe Murder case, noticed a dramatic change in VOC after the Surat Congress and the founding of the Chennai Jana Sangam. VOC, he said, 'returned to Tuticorin full of political ideas … What Tilak taught him to do, I do not know, but he became quite a different person after coming from Surat'. Attributing VOC's ardour to imbibing Tilak's ideas expressed in *The Tenets of the New Party*,[9] he said, VOC 'began to deliver absurdly violent lectures against the government'. Neelakanta Brahmachari also mistakenly claimed that, after Surat, VOC lost all interest in the shipping company, and 'in fact, he wished it were stopped that he may devote his whole time to Swadeshi politics'.[10] Though these remarks were made in a self-serving statement meant to exonerate himself from the conspiracy to murder Ashe, the description of VOC's patriotic zeal after Surat can hardly be faulted.

Collector Wynch, at the helm of the district administration, also noted this transformation. Dubbing VOC 'the arch traitor', he described him as 'a firebrand of the worst type of the Extremist party—he went to Surat and out-heroed heroes there. To win his private ends i.e. as agent secretary of SSNCo, he has systematically preached the extremist propaganda at Tuticorin for the last three months.'[11]

On his return to Tuticorin, VOC was at the forefront, organizing Swadeshi meetings. For some two months beginning in early January 1908, until he was arrested in the middle of March, there was hardly a day when public meetings were not held. These meetings received a fillip with the